

AI Art as a Cultural System

A01: Interpreting AI Art through a Cultural Systems Lens

Clifford Geertz famously argued that art, like religion, operates as a **cultural system** of symbols whose meanings emerge from use and social context ¹. In Geertz's words, the "meaning arises in use" and understanding art requires a "*new diagnostics*" – "*a science which can determine the meaning of things for the life that surrounds them... to locate in the tenor of their setting the sources of their spell*" ¹. Following Geertz's insight, we approach **AI art** not as an isolated technical output but as embedded in cultural practices, contexts and interpretations. In recent years AI-based art has rapidly "*expanded, gained visibility, and attained socio-cultural relevance*", engaging a range of disciplines and audiences beyond traditional art worlds ². This surge of AI-generated images, texts, and performances calls for just the kind of contextual interpretation Geertz envisioned. We must examine not only the algorithms, but **how people use, value, and ritualize AI art** – from online communities sharing prompts to galleries debating its status – to understand the "*meaning of things*" in this new artistic milieu ¹.

To structure such an inquiry, we integrate multiple theoretical perspectives. Geertz's semiotic anthropology provides the overarching notion that AI art's significance lies in its *meaning-in-use*. Building on this, we will draw connections across narrative theory, literary theory, media philosophy, digital humanities, cybernetics, and systems theory. Each of the following sections (A02–A08) will examine AI art through one of these lenses while also weaving in examples from contemporary AI-driven creative practices (text, image, video, interactive media). The goal is a **cross-domain synthesis**: much like a cultural anthropologist reading a ritual, we read AI art as **symbolic action** within broader narrative, technological, and social systems. By doing so, we hope to answer Geertz's call for "*new diagnostics*" of aesthetic power ¹ suited to AI art – diagnostics that account for the interplay of code and culture, and for the "*sources of [AI art's] spell*" in our emergent technological life ¹.

A02: Narrative Theory and the Implied Author of AI Creativity

One fruitful lens is **narrative theory**, which helps address questions of authorship, intention, and story in AI-generated art. Traditional literary theory distinguishes between the *real author* (the actual creator of a text) and the *implied author* (the inferred voice or persona that a reader perceives within the text) ³. This distinction is remarkably useful in the context of AI art. When we encounter a short story written by GPT-3 or a script like *Sunspring* (the 2016 short film authored by an LSTM neural network), there is by definition no single human "author" with intent and emotion. Yet, as readers or viewers, we naturally construct an **implied authorial voice** from the work itself ³. Narrative theory reminds us that "*seeing a specific intentionality in the text does not mean*" we know "*the actual process that produced that text*". We "*imagine the [author] expressed by [the work's] content and style*", a "*reader-created construct that is different from who (or what) the actual creator is*" ³. In other words, even if an AI system generated the content, audiences still engage with a *persona* or narrative presence emerging from the piece, treating the **AI or its human collaborator as an implied storyteller**.

This has important implications for meaning-making in AI art. Critics often argue that AI-generated art lacks depth because there is no human artist's psyche behind it – no *“emotion, passion, [or] turmoil that the artist might have felt”* during creation ⁴. For example, an AI-rendered painting in the style of Jackson Pollock might be visually convincing, yet some viewers feel it is missing the authentic existential angst that they would normally *read into* Pollock's drip paintings ⁴. However, through the lens of narrative and literary theory, we can see that audiences tend to supply their own interpretations and intentions to the artwork regardless. The **“death of the Author,”** as Barthes put it, is perhaps reprised in AI art – what matters is the interplay between the *text* (or image) and the spectator, not the presence of a flesh-and-blood author. In practice, people *do* find narratives and meanings in AI art, often projecting onto the work a storytelling logic or aesthetic intent. The concept of the implied author helps explain why: humans are *sense-making creatures*, quick to assume a narrative agency within any creative work. Thus, an AI artwork can *“speak”* to us culturally even when its creator is an algorithm, because we interact with it as we would any narrative artifact – by constructing meaning through interpretation and cultural context. **AI art, then, becomes a new test case for narrative theory**, challenging us to rethink creativity and authorship beyond the human, yet reaffirming that meaning ultimately emerges through the act of reading, viewing, or engaging with the work in its cultural setting.

A03: Media Philosophy – Technology's Imprint on Aesthetics and Meaning

From the perspective of **media philosophy**, AI art exemplifies Marshall McLuhan's dictum that “the medium is the message.” The technical architecture of AI systems – the data, algorithms, and interfaces – profoundly shapes the form and experience of the art created. Media theorist Friedrich Kittler observed that *“the study of literature, art, and culture cannot be separated from the study of the media technologies that make them possible.”* ⁵ In the case of AI art, the *media technology* is not just paint or canvas, but code libraries, neural network models, and cloud-based generative platforms. These impose their own **affordances and constraints** on artistic expression. For instance, Generative Adversarial Networks (GANs) tend to produce images with a distinctive *visual indeterminacy* – pictures that *“appear to depict real scenes, but on closer examination, defy coherent spatial interpretation.”* This trait has been noted as *“a key feature of much...GAN art.”* A researcher hypothesizes that such *indeterminacy* is a direct *“consequence of a powerful-but-imperfect image synthesis model”* trying to blend diverse visual patterns ⁶. In other words, the **algorithm's structure and training data leave aesthetic fingerprints**: slightly warped compositions, surreal juxtapositions, or the infamous inability of early models to render human hands correctly. These machine-specific aesthetics – the glitch, the strange dream-like quality – are not just quirks; they become new artistic devices that viewers now interpret for meaning (often seeing them as evocative or uncanny).

Media philosophy also urges us to consider how **AI systems function as artistic apparatuses**. Vilém Flusser's analysis of photography applies here: photographers program their cameras by choosing settings, angles, etc., and the apparatus in turn “writes” the image. Similarly, AI artists “program” their neural networks via training sets and prompts, but the *apparatus* (the AI) generates the final output beyond direct human control. The result is a *hybrid authorship* where creative agency is distributed between human and machine. The **materiality of the AI (its code, algorithmic logic)** actively participates in the creation of meaning. For example, a style-transfer algorithm will impart a recognizable texture to every image it processes, effectively **co-authoring** the aesthetic. Furthermore, the rise of AI art has prompted media theorists to note that we often misattribute creative qualities to the technology itself. Lev Manovich argues that there is *“no such thing as ‘AI aesthetics.’ There are only different users who have different tastes, and*

different degrees of visual competence.” What looks like a unified “AI art style” is often just the statistical dominance of certain popular outputs on platforms ⁷. In other words, what “*you think comes from the ‘machine’ in reality comes from its users.*” ⁸ The **illusion of a singular AI-driven style** is actually a reflection of human cultural patterns (e.g. many users prompting in similar styles) rather than an inherent property of the algorithms. This viewpoint reinforces that technology and culture are deeply intertwined: the machine facilitates and filters creative expression, but human choices and cultural contexts drive the interpretation. Media philosophy thus helps us see AI art as *socio-technical artifacts*, where meaning arises from the interplay of technical media features (like GAN indeterminacy) with human aesthetic judgement and cultural usage.

A04: Cross-Disciplinary Cultural Analytics – Data, Patterns, and Interpretation

If AI art sits at the intersection of art and computation, then the field of **digital humanities and cultural analytics** offers tools to both study and create within this intersection. Cultural analytics, as defined by Lev Manovich and others, involves using data-driven methods to analyze media and cultural artifacts ⁹. Interestingly, this approach can turn back on AI art itself: not only can we analyze traditional art with AI, we can also analyze *AI-generated art and its reception* to gain insight into cultural patterns. For example, researchers might collect thousands of images produced by a popular text-to-image generator and examine them for stylistic trends, biases, or narratives. Such an analysis could reveal that certain aesthetic tropes (say, **surreal landscapes or anime-style portraits**) dominate – information which in turn reflects the biases of the user community or the training data. One study in *AI & Society* notes that discussions around AI art often become a “*battle of metaphors*,” as people frame the technology in differing ways (e.g. AI as **tool, collaborator, or creative agent**) – each metaphor carrying its own cultural narrative about what AI art is ¹⁰. By quantitatively analyzing texts (like art reviews or social media posts about AI art), cultural analytics can map these narrative frames and how they shift over time or across communities.

Beyond analysis, the **data-centric paradigm** of digital art is itself a theme in AI art. Artists are leveraging archives and datasets in creative ways, blurring the line between data analysis and art-making. A telling example is an AI art project that generates fake historical photographs to critique archives (this will be detailed in A07). In such works, the *dataset* (historical photos, in that case) and the *algorithm* jointly produce an artistic statement about memory and bias. Scholars like Dejan Grba propose comprehensive frameworks to critically evaluate these practices, emphasizing that we must address the “*poetic, expressive, and ethical layers*” of AI art in context ¹¹. Grba suggests situating AI art within “*the broader milieu of contemporary culture, AI science/technology, economy, and society*,” examining both its *accomplishments and shortcomings* ¹¹. This is a quintessentially digital humanities mindset: treat AI art as an object of study that requires **contextualization across multiple domains** (technical, cultural, political). Journals like *Leonardo* and the *Journal of Cultural Analytics* have accordingly begun publishing work that treats visualizations and generative outputs as both aesthetic objects and data for inquiry ⁹. For instance, one article explored the **aesthetic value of cultural data visualizations**, essentially turning analytics into art ⁹. Such cross-domain projects highlight that in the era of AI, creation and analysis intermingle. **AI art is inherently meta**: it’s art created by algorithms, often about algorithms or data, inviting us to analyze it with the same rigor we analyze culture at large. The cultural analytics lens thus not only helps dissect patterns in AI art (e.g. common genres, algorithmic biases, audience reactions), but also feeds back into practice, where understanding those patterns can inspire artists and critics to push the medium’s boundaries or address its blind spots.

A05: Cybernetics and Systems Theory – Feedback Loops and Autonomy in AI Art

AI art can also be examined through the lens of **cybernetics and systems theory**, focusing on feedback, interactivity, and the system-like behavior of art itself. In the mid-20th century, early computer art and installations were often explicitly cybernetic – incorporating feedback loops with the audience or environment. That legacy continues in many AI-driven artworks today. Consider interactive installations where an AI system responds to the viewer's presence or input: the artwork is not a static object but a **dynamic system** that includes the spectator as a component. For example, media artist Ken Feingold's installations (like *If/Then* and *Sinking Feeling*, 2001) feature animatronic heads engaged in an endless AI-driven conversation. The dialogue generated by the NLP system is “*semantically plausible but ultimately senseless*”¹² – the two heads seem to converse, yet there is no real meaning, highlighting the audience's impulse to *impose* meaning on the exchange. Such works hark back to cybernetic art's fascination with “*the meaning of meaning*”: the viewer watches a feedback loop of language that invites interpretation but frustrates it, thereby making us aware of our own role in generating meaning. Feingold and others (e.g. interactive robot artists like Louis-Philippe Demers or Patrick Tresset) in the 1990s and 2000s “*articulated some of [AI] art's contemporary topics*” by creating “*uncanny*” systems that question agency, creativity, and the boundaries of human-machine interaction¹³. These artists treated art as an **autonomous system** – sometimes literally (the artwork moves or speaks on its own) – and probed what happens when a system's behavior escapes direct human control.

Niklas Luhmann's systems theory posits that art is a self-referential social system, one that communicates in a language of forms and affects. In Luhmann's view, art has *autopoiesis*: it continuously reproduces itself by selecting and recombining perceptions to create new experiences within the “art system.” AI art brings a new twist to this idea. On one hand, the **AI model itself is an autopoietic system** in a technical sense – for example, a GAN's generator and discriminator engage in a recursive loop, improving (or at least evolving) through their feedback interplay. On the other hand, critics like Luciana Parisi warn that much of what passes for autonomous AI creativity actually “*reactivates the modern structure of self-posed (autodecisional) thinking*”, reinforcing a closed loop of human norms¹⁴. She argues that current AI often carries “*a recursive epistemology*” that mirrors its training data, leading to an “*autopoiesis as the reduction of difference (qua alienness)*” – in plainer terms, AI can too easily become a mirror that feeds back our own biases and conventions¹⁴. From this critical angle, the task for AI art is to break out of that closed loop and introduce *difference*. Notably, some AI artworks deliberately inject randomness or *noise* as a creative element, embracing the unexpected outputs of a system rather than steering it to safe averages. This aligns with second-order cybernetics, where the observer (or artist/programmer) becomes part of the system and may choose to **perturb the system** to explore new possibilities. The “new diagnostics” for AI art's aesthetic power might then involve examining how effectively an artwork leverages feedback and unpredictability to generate novel meanings.

Case studies of cybernetic AI art illustrate both the promise and challenge of autonomous systems. **Interactive narrative pieces** like Jonas Eltes' *Lost in Computation* (2017) put two chatbots into conversation and invite the audience to derive sense from their nonsense¹². The installation becomes a mirror for the viewer's own meaning-making process, essentially a feedback loop between human interpretation and machine output. Similarly, AI-generated music performances (like live algorithms improvising with human musicians) create cybernetic duets where control is shared and emergent patterns arise that neither partner fully intended. Systems theory helps us see these artworks as **communicative systems**: their

meaning does not reside in any single component (not in the human alone, nor the machine alone) but in the *interactions* and differences that play out over time. By treating AI art as a system, we can analyze how information flows – e.g. how a viewer’s reaction might feed back into an adaptive artwork, or how an AI model “learns” from human curation (when artists iteratively refine outputs). In sum, the cybernetic lens emphasizes **process over object**. It asks: *What is the behavior of this art system? How does it engage participants in feedback?* And, crucially, *does it merely reinforce its own logic, or can it surprise us?* The most compelling AI artworks often introduce *pressure points* that reveal the system’s limits or lead it into novel territory (as when an AI produces a poetic glitch). In doing so, they echo Geertz’s notion of finding the “sources of their spell” ¹ – here, the spell might lie in the fascinating autonomy and **liveness** of an artwork that behaves with a life of its own.

A06: Multimodal Narratives and the Fusion of Forms in AI Art

AI art is not confined to a single medium – it spans **text, image, sound, video, and interactive experiences**, often blending them into new multimodal narrative forms. One trend is the emergence of AI-assisted storytelling that combines visual and textual generation. For instance, experimental projects have used GPT-3 to write story text while using text-to-image models (like DALL-E or Stable Diffusion) to illustrate each scene, resulting in an AI-“co-authored” graphic novel or storybook. These works highlight the **multimodal potential** of AI: language models can provide narrative structure and dialogue, while image models provide the visuals, together creating a synthetic narrative experience. In a more performance-oriented vein, British artist Jake Elwes’s “**The Zizi Show**” (2020) is a virtual drag cabaret that uses deepfake AI to layer faces of drag performers, generating a continuously morphing drag performance. Elwes explicitly designed this piece to *critique* the technology – “*Zizi Show*” “*critiques both anthropomorphism and [the] error-prone gender inclusiveness of AI*”, by showing AI’s attempt to simulate gender-fluid drag personas ¹⁵. The result is part spectacle, part social commentary: it tells a *story* about AI’s gaze on gender. Here the *narrative* is not linear like a novel, but conceptual – the audience witnesses an AI system struggling to perform queerness, thereby exposing the biases and constraints coded into mainstream datasets (which often have trouble with non-binary and fluid representations). This exemplifies how **AI art can embody theoretical critique**: the medium (deepfake tech) and content (drag show) merge to pose questions about who is seen and how.

Another exemplar is *Cacophonous Choir* (2020), an award-winning interactive installation by Şölen Kıratlı, Hannah Wolfe, and Alex Bundy, which artfully integrates sound, sculpture, and narrative. The installation consists of nine sculptural “*vocalizing agents*” dispersed in a space, each one associated with a first-person story of a sexual assault survivor ¹⁶. When a visitor enters the space, they initially hear a cacophony of garbled voices – a metaphor for how survivors’ voices can be drowned out or distorted in mass media noise. As one approaches an individual sculpture, however, “*the story becomes sonically clearer and semantically more coherent*,” until at close range “*the viewer hears the first-hand account*” from that survivor ¹⁶. **The artwork thus creates an embodied narrative experience**: distance and proximity become like turning the pages of a story, revealing personal narratives out of an abstract hum. *Cacophonous Choir* demonstrates a sophisticated multimodal narrative technique. Visually, all agents look similar (encased in translucent shells) to symbolize the anonymity imposed by media coverage, but as you engage each one, it lights up and its unique story comes forward ¹⁶. The piece engages **multiple senses and symbolic systems** – sound (voice, noise), text (the content of the stories), space and movement (the viewer’s path), and even light – to convey its meaning. It is informed by media philosophy as well, explicitly referencing how “*digital and mass media...distort*” survivors’ stories and how the #MeToo movement tried to amplify those voices ¹⁷. Through an interactive narrative form, the installation embeds the viewer in a symbolic cybernetic loop: you must

physically move (a bodily ritual) to “tune into” each story, an act that is both literal and metaphorical listening.

Such examples underscore that **AI art often lives in hybridity**. They combine generative text, generative visuals, and interactive logic to create what might be called **system-narratives** or **experiential narratives**. Rather than a fixed storyline, the narrative is something the audience assembles through engagement. This resonates with trends in digital literature and game design, where non-linearity and user agency play a big role. AI adds another layer, because the content itself might be algorithmically varied or personalized. We see early forms of this in AI dungeon-style games where a text AI improvises storylines in response to player input, effectively co-creating a narrative with the player. In visual arts, an AI might generate a sequence of images that evolve based on real-time data (for instance, an installation might visualize live social media feeds as abstract art, telling the “story” of global emotional trends in a day). The theoretical bridge here is to **narrative and media theory combined**: we analyze how stories can be constructed and communicated across sensory modalities, and how AI as a medium introduces variability and generativity into the story. Importantly, multimodal AI artworks still need cultural contextualization. They draw on genres and symbols we recognize (e.g. cabaret, confession, archive, sci-fi), which anchor the audience enough to engage, while the AI element introduces new aesthetic experiences (e.g. the eeriness of a deepfake face that never settles, or the fragmentary grammar of a generated text). In doing so, they expand the notion of what a narrative art piece can be: not just a static tale, but a **living system of symbols** that the audience navigates. These works fulfill Geertz’s idea of art as “*model*” of and *for* reality – *models of* human experiences (like trauma, identity play) and *models for* how we might process those experiences (through new rituals of interaction and interpretation). They suggest that AI art’s cultural power lies in this fusion of form and content: the story is told *through* the workings of an algorithmic system, making the **medium inseparable from the message** in a truly multimodal fashion.

A07: Prompting Rituals, Platform Culture, and Creative Communities



Images from “Un archivo queer inexistente” (2022) by Felipe Rivas San Martín, a fake archive of AI-generated vintage photographs depicting LGBTQ couples. The project constructs a “queer archive of the past” that never

actually existed, using AI to visualize moments that were historically erased ¹⁸. By emphasizing “this was not” – the fact that these tender scenes never happened – the artwork highlights how violence and repression kept such images out of the historical record ¹⁹. Notably, Rivas embraces the telltale AI glitches (e.g. distorted hands or facial quirks) as “evidences of their simulacry character,” an “additional layer of bodily dissidence” that prevents the images from being mistaken for real and underscores their role as imaginative reclamations of history ²⁰.

The example above also illuminates the **sociotechnical context** of AI art creation, especially the emerging rituals around *prompting* and platform use. Rivas had to grapple with the biases of a generative model (Stable Diffusion) trained on predominantly heteronormative, Eurocentric images. In doing so, he developed what he calls a “minority prompt” strategy – “an instruction... specifically designed to counteract the inherent biases present in the databases used to train [AI models]” ²¹. This concept of *prompt engineering as activism* is a glimpse into a broader trend: **communities of AI artists and enthusiasts coalescing around prompt-crafting as a new creative skill**. Indeed, recent research confirms that “*prompt engineering is a new type of skill*” that must be learned through practice ²². In a study, even crowd participants could tell a good prompt from a bad one and improved at writing prompts with training, though novices lacked the “*style-specific vocabulary*” that experienced prompters develop ²³. This points to the rise of a **shared lore and technique** – effectively, a *folk art* of prompt-crafting. Online platforms and communities (such as the Midjourney Discord, Reddit’s r/AIArt, or specialized forums) are the sites where this knowledge is exchanged. Users post images alongside the text prompts that generated them, turning prompt-sharing into a communal workshop and even a performative act. The culture has invented its own rituals: some treat complex prompt strings like recipes or magic spells, iterating and swapping components (“try adding --analog style or referencing Greg Rutkowski for a fantasy vibe,” etc.). In Rivas’s case, his *minority prompt* technique is shared as a political and creative tip for others to produce more diverse representations ²¹. Thus, prompting becomes not only a technical interaction with an AI, but a **symbolic act within a community**, with values and intents (inclusivity, originality, subversion) guiding the way prompts are crafted.

Parallel to the craft of prompting is the influence of **platform culture** on the aesthetics and dissemination of AI art. Generative art tools are often centralized (a handful of powerful models, like DALL·E, Midjourney, Stable Diffusion, GPT, etc., dominate usage) and they each have *default biases* or popular styles that trend among users. Lev Manovich notes that the “*great majority of visual AI users*” gravitate towards certain mass tastes (often reflecting familiar pop culture or kitsch aesthetics), and because they are so prolific, their output floods the online space ⁷ ²⁴. This creates the illusion of an “AI art style” – for instance, glossy anime girls or surreal futuristic landscapes might seem like what *AI inherently produces*, but in truth this is a byproduct of user preferences and the training data they lean on. “*What you think comes from the ‘machine’ in reality comes from its users*,” Manovich stresses ⁸. In these early days of widespread AI art, people tend to *over-attribute* aesthetic outcomes to the technology, when often it’s **platform-driven network effects**. The platforms themselves nudge users: for example, the Midjourney algorithm has a particular *high-fidelity, illustrative look* that has become a de facto style because the system’s rewards (how it ranks and displays images) favor that look. In response, savvy users compile extensive prompt guides and style libraries – there are “*very long tables with style references for Midjourney*”, documenting how to invoke hundreds of art styles or even mimic specific artists ²⁵. This democratization of style knowledge means that a novice can quickly produce images in a known style by copying a prompt formula, but it also reinforces formulaic outputs. Meanwhile, **institutions and the art world** are adapting: major galleries and competitions have started to feature AI art (occasionally stirring controversy, as when an AI-generated piece won a digital art prize). The **platformization** of art raises new questions about authorship and value – an ongoing debate is

“Who authors AI art? (And why does it matter?)” ²⁶ . If a thousand users can generate a similar image from the same model, how do we assign credit or uniqueness? Some argue the art is in the prompt (the human idea and curation), others say the real author is the machine’s **creators** (the researchers who coded or trained it). These discussions reflect what Geertz would recognize as *meaning-in-use*: the community negotiations and institutional decisions are actively constructing what AI art *means* (e.g., as **art or not-art**, as **craft or click**, as **authentic creation or mere remix**).

In summary, looking at AI art via its social and platform dimension reveals it as a **cultural practice** as much as a set of artifacts. The prompting rituals are like the performative aspect of this practice – a new kind of artistic **ritual** where incantations (text prompts) are given to an oracle (the AI) to yield a vision. The community aspect highlights **cultural systems at play**: norms, shared vocabularies, mentorship (people sharing tips), and even taboos (many communities ban certain content or have ethical guidelines, e.g. against NSFW or deepfake abuse). Platform culture also ties into economic and institutional systems – for instance, AI art marketplaces and the role of tech companies (as noted, companies like OpenAI and Google have actively supported AI art via grants and residencies ²⁷ , which in turn shape what gets created and exhibited). By observing these elements, we complete the picture of AI art as not just images or poems floating in isolation, but as **embedded in a sociotechnical network**: tools, people, values, and behaviors all interlinked. The *meaning* of an AI-generated artwork can thus be deeply influenced by these contexts – a fact which any adequate “new diagnostics” of AI aesthetics must account for.

A08: Synthesis – AI Art in Symbolic, Cybernetic, and Sociotechnical Systems

Bringing together these perspectives, we can see **AI art as a cultural system** in Geertz’s sense: a sphere of meaningful activity that both represents and shapes the world of its participants. AI art exists at the nexus of *symbolic systems* (language, images, narratives), *cybernetic systems* (feedback loops between human and machine, adaptive behaviors), and *sociotechnical systems* (platforms, communities, institutions). Each analytical lens we applied reveals a different facet, but they are ultimately complementary. Below is a brief synthesis of how these domains converge to illuminate AI art’s significance:

- **Narrative & Literary Theory:** Shows that audiences construct stories and infer “implied authors” in AI art ³ , ensuring that even without a human creator, AI artworks are woven into cultural narratives and interpretations. It highlights issues of authorship, intent, and the *reader’s role* in making meaning.
- **Media Philosophy & Technology:** Emphasizes that the medium (AI algorithms, training data) strongly shapes content – from GANs’ *visual indeterminacy* ⁶ to the biases in datasets. It reminds us that AI art’s forms are co-produced by technological constraints and affordances, and cautions against attributing creativity to “the machine” without recognizing user influence ²⁸ .
- **Digital Humanities & Cultural Analytics:** Encourages us to treat AI art as data and discourse that can be systematically analyzed (e.g. for style trends or metaphorical framings). It also notes how AI art entangles with data practices – artworks can be critiques of datasets (as in Rivas’s archive) or results of data visualization turning into art ⁹ . This domain stresses interdisciplinary methods to evaluate AI art’s cultural impact (quantitative and qualitative analysis side by side).
- **Cybernetics & Systems Theory:** Draws attention to feedback, interactivity, and emergent behavior in AI art. It frames artworks as systems where meaning emerges dynamically (e.g. viewer interaction

causing narrative to materialize in *Cacophonous Choir* ¹⁶). It also provides concepts like autopoiesis to question whether AI art systems reinforce existing patterns or generate genuine novelty ¹⁴ .

- **Cultural/Social Systems:** Focuses on the social context – the communities of practice (prompt engineers, online forums), the institutional reception (museums, galleries, competitions adapting to AI art), and the broader societal conversations (ethics, authenticity, intellectual property). It underscores that AI art is **embedded in a network of social relations and economic structures**, from corporate AI labs to open-source collectives, which profoundly affect how the art is produced and valued ²⁷ .

Crucially, these aspects do not operate in isolation but interact. For example, the *symbolic content* of an AI artwork (say, a queer archival photo) gains power through a *sociotechnical act* (prompting with a minority consciousness) and might be presented in an *interactive system* (an online platform where viewers can generate their own versions). In this way, AI art is **systemic**: meaning is distributed across technical infrastructure, human interpretation, and cultural narrative. It calls to mind Geertz's assertion that understanding art requires looking at "*the tenor of [its] setting*" to find "*the sources of [its] spell*" ¹ . In the setting of 2020s AI art, those sources include things like the design of a user interface, the rules of a community, the biases of a dataset, the references to art history embedded in a model's training, and the intentions of the artist-programmer – all at once.

Returning to Geertz's idea of "*new diagnostics*" ¹ : what would a diagnostic toolkit for AI art's cultural meaning look like? Based on our exploration, it would be inherently cross-disciplinary. It might involve **"reading" an AI artwork on multiple levels** – as a narrative (what story or theme does it evoke?), as a media artifact (how was it made, what are its formal qualities?), as a social act (who made it, for whom, and in what context?), and as a system (how does it behave or change?). It would also involve *comparative insight*: placing AI art in historical context (e.g. how is an AI portrait different from a photograph in the age of mechanical reproduction?) and global context (noting that AI art practices vary around the world, influenced by local cultures and issues). In Fischer's update to Geertz, he notes contemporary art often "*speaks back against...globalization, postcolonialism, neoliberalism...*" with new cosmopolitan tactics ²⁹ . Indeed, AI art has been used to question global power dynamics – from exposing racial bias in facial recognition to imagining alternative futures by hacking corporate AI tools. These critical works fulfill what Luciana Parisi suggests AI might do for the humanities: "*expose the allopoetic (other-made) and allotropic (other-place) thinking*" that breaks our habitual frames ³⁰ . In other words, AI art at its best can help us **think otherwise** – to see the world from a slightly alien but illuminating perspective, whether by generating images of lives erased from history, or by simulating countless artistic styles to remind us that creativity is not a single human monopoly but a space of possibilities.

Finally, the cultural system of AI art is still evolving. As of 2025, we observe a burst of innovation coupled with contestation. *Critical Inquiry* and *Theory, Culture & Society* have started to theorize AI's impact on concepts of art and the human; journals like *AI & Society* and *Leonardo* document both the artworks and the debates. The "*battle of metaphors*" around AI art – tool vs. creator, mimicry vs. innovation – will likely shape its trajectory ³¹ . But if we've learned anything from this cross-domain survey, it's that AI art can only be fully understood by **bridging disciplines and contexts**, much like a cultural anthropologist studying a ritual by examining its symbols, practitioners, performative actions, and social roles all at once. AI art is a *ritual of our technoscientific society* – a ritual in which we enact hopes and fears about technology, creativity, and identity. By studying it as a cultural system, we not only decode its meaning-in-use today, but also gain insight into broader cultural transformations. In Geertz's terms, AI art is both "*model of*" our culture (reflecting our collective imagination about AI) and "*model for*" potential new cultural practices (suggesting new ways of making and valuing art) ³² ³³ . As we continue to develop a diagnostic science of these

practices, we remain attentive to the **life that surrounds the art** – the human life and social world in which artificial creativity takes on real significance. By doing so, we honor Geertz's vision, teasing out the sources of the spell that AI art casts on contemporary culture, and in turn, understanding a bit more about ourselves in the mirror of our machines.

Sources: The analysis above synthesizes insights from diverse literature, including Clifford Geertz's seminal essay *Art as a Cultural System* ¹, recent theoretical reflections on AI and art in anthropology and critical theory ³⁴ ¹⁴ ³⁰, as well as case studies and discussions from *Leonardo* ⁶ ³⁵, *AI & Society* ¹⁸ ²⁰, *Journal of Cultural Analytics*, and other scholarly and artistic sources. Each section contains specific citations to these works, illustrating the points made with direct evidence from researchers, artists, and critics engaged in this evolving dialogue on AI art and culture.

¹ ²⁹ ³² ³³ ³⁴ Challenging Art as Cultural Systems . . . for Cliff from the Twenty-First Century: Light Shows, Shadow Plays, Pressure Points | Society for Cultural Anthropology

<https://culanth.org/fieldsights/challenging-art-as-cultural-systems>

² ¹¹ ¹² ¹³ ¹⁵ ²⁷ Deep Else: A Critical Framework for AI Art

<https://www.mdpi.com/2673-6470/2/1/1>

³ ⁴ Microsoft Word - Proceeding paper ESA 2023 Arielli

<https://philarchive.org/archive/ARIAAT-8>

⁵ Friedrich Kittler: Theorist of Media and Technology -

<https://gettherapybirmingham.com/friedrich-kittler-theorist-of-media-and-technology/>

⁶ ⁹ ³⁵ Leonardo, Volume 53, Issue 4 | Leonardo/ISASTwith Arizona State University

<https://leonardo.info/journal-issue/leonardo/53/4>

⁷ ⁸ ²⁴ ²⁵ ²⁸ AI aesthetics: A new note on the problem | Lev Manovich posted on the topic | LinkedIn

https://www.linkedin.com/posts/levmanovich_a-new-note-on-ai-aesthetics-5252024-activity-7200136041213665280-MVkg

¹⁰ Articles | AI & SOCIETY

<https://link.springer.com/journal/146/articles>

¹⁴ ³⁰ untitled

<https://www.english.ucsb.edu/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/185raley.pdf>

¹⁶ ¹⁷ Cacophonic Choir | Şölen Kıratlı

<https://www.solenk.net/cacophonic-choir>

¹⁸ ¹⁹ ²⁰ ²¹ AI-based generative image production systems in the artistic problematisation of the past: the thematisation of memory and temporality in "AI art" | AI & SOCIETY

<https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s00146-024-02163-z>

²² ²³ [2303.13534] Prompting AI Art: An Investigation into the Creative Skill of Prompt Engineering

<https://arxiv.org/abs/2303.13534>

²⁶ AI & SOCIETY | The Philosophy Paperboy

<https://thephilosophypaperboy.com/feeds/ai-society/>

³¹ (PDF) Creative AI: From Expressive Mimicry to Critical Inquiry

https://www.researchgate.net/publication/343108987_Creative_AI_From_Expressive_Mimicry_to_Critical_Inquiry